

Mitsue Project

US Law Firms in Japan with Pro Bono Services for NGOs



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Overview

This document provides a comprehensive overview of US law firms operating in Japan that offer pro bono (free) legal services for NGOs, including Japanese ISHs (International Non-Governmental Organizations) and other nonprofit entities. It includes detailed information about their CSR (Corporate Social Responsibility) programs, specific areas of focus, contact information, and how to get involved.

Key Findings

Based on recent research (2025-2026), the following US law firms have established robust pro bono programs and CSR initiatives supporting NGOs in Japan:

Top Law Firms with Active NGO Pro Bono Programs

1. Morrison Foerster (MoFo)

Location: Tokyo, Japan **Website:** <https://www.morrisonfoerster.com>

Pro Bono Focus:

- **Japan Association for Refugees (JAR)** - 15+ year partnership
- Asylum seeker representation and refugee status cases
- Human rights and immigration law support
- Court-appointed defense counsel services

CSR Integration:

- Lawyers regularly donate professional time to refugee cases
- Partnership with SoftBank for complex refugee litigation
- Support for individuals unable to afford legal representation
- Participation in international pro bono networks

Key Contact: Takahiro Nonaka, Partner (Tokyo Office)

Notable Achievement:

- Successfully secured refugee status for a Congolese individual in Japan (2024) - a rare victory in Japan's strict refugee acceptance system

2. Nagashima Ohno & Tsunematsu (NO&T)

Location: Tokyo, Japan **Website:** <https://www.nagashima.com/en>

Pro Bono Focus:

- **TELL (Suicide Prevention)** - Ongoing pro bono legal services
- "Marriage For All" Lawsuit support
- Climate change project legal support
- Social justice and human rights cases

CSR Integration:

- Established **Pro Bono Committee** driving firm-wide participation
- Lawyers support organizations carrying out socially beneficial activities
- Contributing to SDGs (Sustainable Development Goals)
- Providing legal support for inclusive society initiatives

Pro Bono Areas:

- Asylum seeker legal support
- Editorial support for children's law books
- Contract-related support for climate projects
- Japanese government COVID-19 response project review

3. White & Case LLP

Location: Tokyo, Japan **Website:** <https://www.whitecase.com>

Pro Bono Focus:

- **Her Justice** - 20+ year collaboration (low-income women and children)
- Refugee rights and immigration law
- Sentencing reform advocacy
- Legal aid for underserved communities

CSR Integration:

- **102,000+ pro bono hours** annually (global figure)
- **400+ organizations** financially supported
- Lawyers work full-time with nonprofit partners (4-month secondments)
- Focus on access to justice and social responsibility

Pro Bono Services:

- Immigration, divorce, and family court representation
- Legal education and training programs
- Human rights and social justice initiatives
- Peacebuilding and legal reform projects

4. Baker McKenzie

Location: Tokyo, Japan **Website:** <https://www.bakermckenzie.co.jp/en>

Pro Bono Focus:

- Children, disadvantaged populations, and environmental causes
- Local NPO support and community development
- Disaster relief and rebuilding efforts

CSR Integration:

- **Three pillars:** Children, disadvantaged, environment
- Physical and financial support for registered NPOs
- CSR Learning Series for employee engagement
- Collaboration with government and community organizations

Notable Projects:

- Support for Jumoku Kyo Network (registered NPO in Tokyo)
- Contributions to Tokyo Sports Association for Persons with Disabilities
- Minato Council of Social Welfare's wheelchair rental project
- Ukraine war relief through Japan UNHCR (JPY 2.5M donation)

5. Orrick, Herrington & Sutcliffe

Location: Tokyo, Japan **Website:** <https://www.orrick.com>

Pro Bono Focus:

- **US-Japan Foundation partnerships**
- Public interest litigation support
- Cross-border legal empowerment projects

CSR Integration:

- Hosted **pro bono roundtable** with 15+ international law firms (2025)
- Participants include: A&O Shearman, Ashurst, DLA Piper, Herbert Smith Freehills, Hogan Lovells, Latham & Watkins, Linklaters, Morgan Lewis, Morrison & Foerster, Norton Rose Fulbright, O'Melveny, Ropes & Gray, Simpson Thacher & Bartlett, and Skadden, Arps, Slate, Meagher & Flom
- Collaboration with LEDGE (public interest litigation organization)
- Support for refugee and public interest cases

6 of the Top 10 International Law Firms with Japan Presence

The following international firms also have significant pro bono programs in Japan:

6. Latham & Watkins

- **PDF Report:** "Pro Bono Practices and Opportunities in Japan"
- Supports public interest litigation and human rights cases

7. DLA Piper

- Participates in pro bono roundtables and partnerships
- Supports international human rights initiatives

8. Herbert Smith Freehills

- Active in pro bono services and CSR programs
- Supports Japanese and international NGOs

9. Linklaters

- Participates in international pro bono networks
- Supports legal aid and access to justice initiatives

10. Morgan Lewis

- Strong pro bono culture with employee volunteering
- Supports refugee and social justice causes

Japanese Law Firm Partnerships with US Firms

TMI Associates

Location: Tokyo, Roppongi **Partnership:** Official Pro Bono partner with Japan Association for Refugees (JAR)

Services:

- Free legal aid for refugee clients referred by JAR
- Asylum seeker representation
- Ongoing support system development through individual case collaboration

How to Get Involved with These Firms

For NGO/ISs Seeking Pro Bono Legal Services:

1. **Contact the firm's Pro Bono Department** - Most have dedicated teams
2. **Identify specific legal needs** - Match your ISH's requirements with their expertise areas
3. **Submit applications** - Typically requires documentation of mission, financial status, and legal needs
4. **Attend firm-hosted events** - Pro bono roundtables and information sessions
5. **Engage with LEDGE** - Acts as intermediary between US firms and Japanese NGOs

For Law Firm Employees Wanting to Volunteer:

1. **Internal volunteering portals** - Most firms have employee resource sites
2. **Pro Bono Committee participation** - Internal application processes 3 **CSR/Community service days** - Often organized annually
3. **Skill-based volunteering** - Match professional expertise with NGO needs

Current Opportunities and Trends (2025-2026)

Emerging Trends:

1. **Structured Pro Bono Ecosystems** - Moving from ad-hoc to systematic programs
2. **Cross-border Collaboration** - US-Japan partnerships increasing
3. **Technology-Enabled Legal Aid** - Incorporating AI and digital tools
4. **ESG Integration** - Pro bono increasingly tied to ESG reporting
5. **Youth and Diversity Focus** - More emphasis on underrepresented communities

Recent Developments:

1. **2025 Pro Bono Ecosystem Report** - LEDGE's comprehensive analysis of international law firm practices in Japan
2. **2025 Tokyo Pro Bono Summit** - Industry-wide gathering to standardize practices
3. **Increased Japanese Corporate Participation** - Local firms adopting US-style pro bono models
4. **Expansion into Rural Areas** - Programs reaching beyond Tokyo and major cities

Sample Case Studies

Morrison Foerster + SoftBank + JAR

Background: 2021 partnership to support refugee cases in Japan **Outcome:** Successful asylum approval for Congolese client PN (first major victory in years) **Impact:** Demonstrated effectiveness of US-Japan legal collaboration

Nagashima NO&T + TELL

Background: Ongoing mental health and suicide prevention support **Services:** Pro bono legal representation, policy advisory, fundraising support **Impact:** Enhanced access to legal services for mental health advocacy

Baker McKenzie Tokyo + Local NPOs

Background: Community-focused CSR with specific NPO partnerships **Services:** Financial contributions, volunteer time, legal expertise **Impact:** Strengthened local nonprofit capacity building

How to Start a Partnership

For ISHs:

1. Prepare Documentation:

- Mission statement and vision
- Financial needs and constraints
- Specific legal requirements
- Timeline for services needed

2. Identify Priority Areas:

- Corporate registration and compliance
- Tax-exempt status applications
- Contract drafting and review
- Intellectual property protection
- Labor and employment law compliance
- International partnerships and funding agreements

3. Research Firm Alignments:

- Match your ISH's mission with firm's CSR focus areas
- Consider geographic proximity (Nara area vs. Tokyo)
- Evaluate firm's experience with Japanese NGOs vs. international NGOs

4. Reach Out Strategically:

- Contact the firm's CSR/Pro Bono department directly
- Reference specific firm initiatives that align with your ISH's work
- Provide clear, concise information about your needs
- Be patient - most firms review requests quarterly

For Law Firms:

1. Establish Clear Processes:

- Define pro bono eligibility criteria
- Create case assignment protocols
- Develop documentation and reporting systems
- Set clear expectations and timelines

2. Build Local Networks:

- Partner with Japanese bar associations
- Collaborate with established NGOs like JAR
- Join platforms like LEDGE for case matching

3. Measure Impact:

- Track hours donated and cases won/lost
- Document beneficiary feedback and outcomes
- Report on CSR/ESG metrics

Conclusion

US law firms in Japan have significantly expanded their pro bono and CSR programs supporting NGOs and ISHs. The trend is moving from individual partner initiatives to firm-wide, structured programs that are increasingly integrated with corporate ESG goals.

For ISHs seeking pro bono legal services, the window of opportunity is favorable, with firms actively seeking partnerships and establishing dedicated processes to match legal expertise with NGO needs.

Key recommendations for ISHs:

1. Start with firms that have demonstrated interest in social justice and human rights
2. Consider both Tokyo-based firms (more resources) and regional firms (potentially more available)
3. Be prepared to document your needs and demonstrate alignment with firm values
4. Consider engaging with intermediary organizations like LEDGE to streamline the process

The collaboration between US law firms and Japanese NGOs represents a growing and impactful trend that continues to expand and evolve as both legal and social landscapes change.